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THE BIRTH OF WIKILEAKS

And so the rubber hits the road. I happen to have seen many institutions from the inside, either by going out to greet them or by hacking their systems and walking through their portals in the night. But in 2006 that exploration came to an end and I wanted to tackle those institutions and those governments, wherever they led their dark lives. I'm not an original political thinker, never claimed to be, but I know the technology and I understand the structures of government; and I was ready to throw the latter, where possible, into a bath of acid and boil them down to the bone. It occurred to me: we can just live our lives complacently, worrying about the mortgage or whether we're famous enough or rich enough or truly loved, or we can look at the bones of our world and test if they are good and true.

When you get stuck into most institutions, you see they float on power and patronage and defend themselves with marketing. That seems to me just a basic truth about the world, though one, I've learned, that most organisations will go to the wall denying. Whether it's the government of Kenya or the Bank Julius Baer, they work for themselves, and they build a clever network of people who can gain by them, and prop them up, while ordinary people are cast into a state of disadvantage. Since my teens, really, I'd been exposed to patronage networks, and I understood their incentives. Any person or organisation that stood against them would be murdered, either in the courts, or by intelligence agents, or in the press. I was ready for them. I had honed the technology and the method of using cryptography to protect sources to a point that I wouldn't even know them myself. We had the activist experience and the will to disempower. We didn't have offices, but we had our laptops and our passports. We had servers in different countries. We knew that we would be the most secure platform for whistleblowers the world had ever known. We had the gumption. We had the philosophy. Game on. I registered WikiLeaks.org on 4 October 2006. I